
Ruben Joseph Fernando

Strengths Discovery and Development Guide

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DON CLIFTON

Father of Strengths Psychology and
Inventor of CliftonStrengths

Ruben Joseph Fernando

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This guide is a starting point, and its purpose is twofold.

First, it should help you discover as you explore what you naturally do best. You possess many unique talents - the ways you consistently and productively think, feel, and behave - and because your talents represent the very best of your nature, they are your greatest opportunities for success.

Second, your guide should help you develop as you move toward strength - the ability to provide consistent, near-perfect performance in a given activity. You can build strengths by identifying your greatest talents, then refining them with knowledge and skills.

Above all, your Strengths Discovery & Development Guide should serve as a starting point. It is a significant resource, but it is not meant to define you or to limit the focus of your strengths development. Listen to your instincts. Consider input from friends, family, and teachers. Your talents are your own, so go where they lead you. Claim those you recognize and value, and use them as the foundation for building toward strength.

Strengths Discovery Questions

As you begin to think about your talents, consider these questions.

1. By what name do you like to be called?
2. What do you naturally do best?
3. To what types of activities do you feel drawn at work and in your personal life?
4. What types of skills and knowledge do you quickly and easily "pick up"?
5. What types of challenges give you the most satisfaction?
6. Have you ever been so engrossed in what you were doing or thinking that you completely lost track of time? If so, what were you doing?
7. What do you get paid to do?
8. What are the key outcomes for which you are held accountable? How is your productivity measured?

Now, turn the page to discover your Signature Themes and actions you can take to build strengths.

Signature Themes and Action Items

On the next five pages you'll find your Signature Themes, which are your five most dominant areas of talent, as indicated by your responses to StrengthsFinder.

Consider your Signature Themes and their descriptions. They can help you understand and, as a result, claim the themes that best represent your natural talents. Which of them best describe your talents - the ways you consistently and productively think, feel, and behave?

Your Signature Themes are a useful resource as you seek to understand your talents. They are based upon your spontaneous, top-of-mind reactions to the paired descriptors presented by StrengthsFinder, and your spontaneous reactions to situations you encounter are the best indicators of your talents.

Your talents are the most important raw material for strength building. Using your Signature Themes and other resources, identify your most powerful talents. Hone them with skill and knowledge to build strengths, and you will be well on your way to living the strong life.

ACTION ITEMS

This guide will help you determine the themes you would like to own for the purpose of talking to others about your strengths and forming your developmental plans.

Following each theme description are action items that can provide insight and direction as you develop and apply strengths. Select the items that best fit your personal development plan, and put them to use as you build toward strength.

Ideation®

You are fascinated by ideas. When you discover an elegantly simple explanation for a complex situation, you are delighted. With a mind that is always looking for connections, you are intrigued when seemingly unrelated events or circumstances are somehow linked to each other. You take the world we know and turn it around so we can see it from a new perspective. You love ideas because they explain, because they clarify, because they connect and because they challenge you to reimagine the familiar. For all these reasons, you get a jolt of energy whenever a new idea occurs to you.

ACTION ITEMS

Seek a career in which you will be given credit for and paid for your ideas, such as marketing, advertising, journalism, design, or new product development.

You are likely to get bored quickly, so make some small changes in your work or home life. Experiment. Play mental games with yourself. All of these will help keep you stimulated.

Finish your thoughts and ideas before communicating them. Lacking your Ideation talents, others might not be able to “join the dots” of an interesting but incomplete idea and thus might dismiss it.

Not all your ideas will be equally practical or serviceable. Learn to edit your ideas, or find a trusted friend or colleague who can “proof” your ideas and identify potential pitfalls.

Understand the fuel for your Ideation talents: When do you get your best ideas? When you’re talking with people? When you’re reading? When you’re simply listening or observing? Take note of the circumstances that seem to produce your best ideas, and recreate them.

Schedule time to read, because the ideas and experiences of others can become your raw material for new ideas. Schedule time to think, because thinking energizes you.

You are a natural fit with research and development; you appreciate the mindset of visionaries and dreamers. Spend time with imaginative peers, and sit in on their brainstorming sessions.

Partner with someone with strong Analytical talents. This person will question you and challenge you, therefore strengthening your ideas.

Sometimes you lose others’ interest because they cannot follow your abstract and conceptual thinking style. Make your ideas more concrete by drawing pictures, using analogies or metaphors, or simply explaining your concepts step by step.

Feed your Ideation talents by gathering knowledge. Study fields and industries different from your own. Apply ideas from outside, and link disparate ideas to generate new ones.

Learner®

You love to learn. The subjects that interest you most will depend on your other themes and experiences, but you will always be drawn to learning. The process of learning, more than the content or the result, is especially exciting for you. The steady progression from ignorance to competence energizes you — the thrill of the first few facts, the early efforts to recite or practice what you have learned, the growing confidence of a skill mastered. You love to engage in new experiences. For example, exploring new activities or fields of study might energize you. You thrive in dynamic environments where you can learn a

lot about a new subject in a short period of time and then move on. You do not necessarily want to become the subject matter expert or earn a professional or academic credential. For you, the outcome is less significant than the journey.

ACTION ITEMS

Refine how you learn. For example, you might learn best by teaching; if so, seek out opportunities to present to others. You might learn best through quiet reflection; if so, find this quiet time.

Develop ways to track the progress of your learning. If there are distinct levels or stages of learning within a discipline or skill, take a moment to celebrate your progression from one level to the next. If no such levels exist, create them for yourself (e.g., reading five books on the subject or making three presentations on the subject).

Be a catalyst for change. Others might be intimidated by new rules, new skills, or new circumstances. Your willingness to soak up this newness can calm their fears and spur them to action. Take this responsibility seriously.

Seek roles that require some form of technical competence. You will enjoy the process of acquiring and maintaining this expertise.

As far as possible, shift your career toward a field with constantly changing technologies or regulations. You will be energized by the challenge of keeping up.

Because you are not threatened by unfamiliar information, you might excel in a consulting role (either internal or external) in which you are paid to go into new situations and pick up new competencies or languages quickly.

Research supports the link between learning and performance. When people have the opportunity to learn and grow, they are more productive and loyal. Look for ways to measure the degree to which you and others feel that your learning needs are being met, to create individualized learning milestones, and to reward achievements in learning.

At work, take advantage of programs that subsidize your learning. Your organization may be willing to pay for part or all of your instructional coursework or for certifications. Ask your manager for information about scholarships and other educational opportunities.

Honor your desire to learn. Take advantage of adult educational opportunities in your community.

Discipline yourself to sign up for at least one new academic or adult learning course each year.

Time disappears and your attention intensifies when you are immersed in studying or learning. Allow yourself to “follow the trail” by scheduling learning sessions during periods of time that will not be interrupted by pressing engagements.

Intellection®

You like to think. You like exercising the “muscles” of your brain, stretching them in multiple directions. Your need for mental activity may be focused. For example, you might be trying to solve a problem, develop an idea or understand another person’s actions. Sometimes, you may think about practical matters such as the events of the day or a conversation you plan to have. The exact focus will depend on your other strengths. There might be times when your mental activity lacks focus. Intellection does not dictate what you think about, just that you like to think. You are introspective, and you enjoy time alone to reflect. You are your own best companion as you ask yourself questions and experiment with answers to see how they sound. This musing will always be a natural part of your life.

ACTION ITEMS

Consider beginning or continuing your studies in philosophy, literature, or psychology. You will always enjoy subjects that stimulate your thinking.

List your ideas in a log or diary. These ideas will serve as grist for your mental mill, and they might yield valuable insights.

Deliberately build relationships with people you consider to be “big thinkers.” Their example will inspire you to focus your own thinking.

People may think you are aloof or disengaged when you close your door or spend time alone. Help them understand that this is simply a reflection of your thinking style, and that it results not from a disregard for relationships, but from a desire to bring the most you can to those relationships.

You are at your best when you have the time to follow an intellectual trail and see where it leads. Get involved on the front end of projects and initiatives, rather than jumping in at the execution stage. If you join in the latter stages, you may derail what has already been decided, and your insights may come too late.

Engaging people in intellectual and philosophical debate is one way that you make sense of things. This is not the case for everyone. Be sure to channel your provocative questions to those who similarly enjoy the

give and take of debate.

Schedule time for thinking; it can be energizing for you. Use these occasions to muse and reflect.

Take time to write. Writing might be the best way for you to crystallize and integrate your thoughts.

Find people who like to talk about the same issues you do. Organize a discussion group that addresses your subjects of interest.

Encourage people around you to use their full intellectual capital by reframing questions for them and by engaging them in dialogue. At the same time, realize that there will be some who find this intimidating and who need time to reflect before being put on the spot.

Responsibility®

You take psychological ownership for anything you commit to, and whether large or small, you feel emotionally bound to follow it through to completion. Your good name depends on it. If for some reason you cannot deliver, apologies are not enough. Excuses and rationalizations are unacceptable. You will not quite be able to live with yourself until you have made restitution. Your conscientiousness, your obsession for doing things right and your impeccable ethics combine to create your reputation: utterly dependable. When people come to you for help — and they will — you must be selective. Your willingness to volunteer may sometimes cause you to take on more than you should.

ACTION ITEMS

Emphasize your sense of responsibility when job hunting. During interviews, describe your desire to be held fully accountable for the success or failure of projects, your intense dislike of unfinished work, and your need to “make it right” if a commitment is not met.

Keep volunteering for more responsibility than your experience seems to warrant. You thrive on responsibility, and you can deal with it very effectively.

Align yourself with others who share your sense of responsibility. You will flourish when working with people who share your determination to get things done.

Tell your manager that you work best when given the freedom to follow through on your commitments — that you don’t need to check in during a project, just at the end. You can be trusted to get it done.

Push yourself to say no. Because you are instinctively responsible, it might sometimes be difficult to refuse opportunities. For this reason, you must be selective. Ask for more responsibility in only the areas that matter most to you.

You naturally take ownership of every project you are involved in. Make sure that your capacity to own does not keep you from sharing responsibility. Allow others the opportunity to experience the challenges of ownership. In doing so, you will contribute to their growth and development.

Learn to manage your Responsibility talents by considering whether you really are the person who should be handling a particular issue. Defer to your existing responsibilities and goals before undertaking additional burdens, as you may end up skimping on quality if you have too many tasks or competing demands.

Partner with someone especially talented in Discipline or Focus. This person can help you stay on track and prevent you from becoming overloaded.

Working with a like-minded, responsible colleague is satisfying for you. Be sure to clarify expectations and boundaries so that each person can feel ownership for his or her particular tasks — without stepping on each other's toes.

Responsible individuals like to know they have “delivered” on their commitments, so create metrics and goals to gauge how effectively you meet your obligations. Also, make sure you have explicit and concrete expectations so that there is no question regarding quality outcomes and so that you can hit the mark as promised.

Connectedness®

Things happen for a reason — you feel it deep in your soul. You know we're all connected in some way. Yes, we have free will, and we're responsible for our own choices. But even so, we're part of something much bigger. You're certain of the oneness of humanity. Some might call it the collective unconscious, spirit or life force. Whatever words resonate with you, understanding that we're not isolated from one another gives you strength — and it comes with certain responsibilities. If we're all part of a greater whole, then hurting others ultimately means hurting ourselves. Exploiting our communities means exploiting ourselves. These beliefs shape your values. You are considerate, caring and accepting. You build bridges between people from different cultures and backgrounds. You reassure others that there's a purpose beyond the routine of daily life. The details of your faith may be influenced by your upbringing and culture, but your faith is steadfast nonetheless. It sustains you and helps you navigate the mysteries of life with

confidence and grace.

ACTION ITEMS

Consider roles in which you listen and counsel. You can become adept at helping other people see connection and purpose in everyday occurrences.

Explore specific ways to expand your sense of connection, such as starting a book club, attending a retreat, or joining an organization that puts Connectedness into practice.

Within your organization, help your colleagues understand how their efforts fit in the larger picture. You can be a leader in building teams and helping people feel important.

You are aware of the boundaries and borders created within organizations and communities, but you treat these as seamless and fluid. Use your Connectedness talents to break down silos that prevent shared knowledge.

Help people see the connections among their talents, their actions, their mission, and their successes. When people believe in what they are doing and feel like they are part of something bigger, commitment to achievement is enhanced.

Partner with someone with strong Communication talents. This person can help you with the words you need to describe vivid examples of connection in the real world.

Don't spend too much time attempting to persuade others to see the world as a linked web. Be aware that your sense of connection is intuitive. If others don't share your intuition, rational argument will not persuade them.

Your philosophy of life compels you to move beyond your own self-interests and the interests of your immediate constituency and sphere of influence. As such, you see the broader implications for your community and the world. Explore ways to communicate these insights to others.

Seek out global or cross-cultural responsibilities that capitalize on your understanding of the commonalities inherent in humanity. Build universal capability, and change the mindset of those who think in terms of "us" and "them."

Connectedness talents can help you look past the outer shell of a person to embrace his or her humanity. Be particularly aware of this when you work with someone whose background is very different from yours.

You can naturally look past the labels and focus on his or her essential needs.

Development Actions

Now that you have discovered your Signature Themes and considered action items for development, please choose 1-3 themes that describe you best, and list them below. Talk to people who know you well, and ask them how they see these themes in you.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Write down three actions that you could take in the next week, month, and year to build and apply your strengths. For ideas and action suggestions by theme, see pages 4-8 of this guide.

In the next week, I will:

- _____
- _____
- _____

In the next month, I will:

- _____
- _____
- _____

In the next year, I will:

- _____
- _____
- _____

Next, please list the name of at least one person who you will meet with to review this plan. Be sure to choose someone who can help you to keep these goals "top-of-mind" and who will help you to leverage your talents to build strengths.

Name: _____

Date reviewed: _____

Name: _____

Date reviewed: _____

Suggestions for Focusing on Strengths

Here is one simple yet helpful key to effectively applying and building strengths: *Think about your talents frequently*. The more you think about your talents, the more likely you will be to use and develop them. Consider the following ideas and select those that you believe will be most helpful.

Create a list of the themes that best describe you. Post it in a spot where you and your friends, family, and teachers will see it every day.

When preparing your To Do list each day, consider your talents. For each task, think about how you can best use your talents to accomplish it. Also consider the skills and knowledge you can add to your talent to build strength.

Use technology. If you send e-mails, list the themes that best describe you as part of your signature line. List those themes in your planner bookmark or load them into your PDA for easy reference.

Write a personal mission statement describing your purpose in life, and create a list of your values. Think about how you can use strengths to follow your values and fulfill your personal mission.

Identify three people who are important to your personal development and fulfillment of your role. Using your top themes as a starting point, talk with them about how, as a group, you can combine your talents to create greater successes.

Don't limit your discussions about talents to the school environment. Use the themes that best describe you as a conversation starter at a social gathering inside or outside of school. You'll be surprised at how changes of environment or perspective can lead to valuable insights.

When you and your friends achieve particular success on a project, consider the strengths and complementary partnerships that may have led to the success.

Help a family member or friend discover their strengths via one of the following books. The more you share the strengths approach with others, the greater your own investment will be.

- StrengthsQuest: Discover and Develop Your Strengths in Academics, Career, and Beyond (<https://store.gallup.com/category/product/variant/272/StrengthsQuest.aspx>)
- Now, Discover Your Strengths (http://gmj.gallup.com/Book_Center/NDYS/default.aspx)
- Discover Your Sales Strengths (http://gmj.gallup.com/Book_Center/DYSS/default.aspx)

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